

Columba livia

Rock dove



Location North, Central, and South America, Africa, Europe, Asia, Australia

Length 12–13½ in (31–34 cm)
Weight 7–11 oz (200–300 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Least concern



Originally from Southern Europe, Asia, and North Africa, the rock dove is the wild ancestor of the town pigeon—one of the world’s most widespread

feral birds. Whereas the wild morph is generally gray, with iridescent highlights on the neck and upper breast, town pigeons are highly variable. Paradoxically, although some feral strains have remarkable homing abilities, wild populations are largely sedentary. The wild rock pigeon nests on sea cliffs and among rocks; for town pigeons, bridges and window ledges provide perfect nest sites.



Columba palumbus

Common wood pigeon



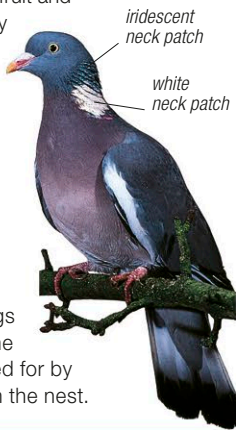
Location Europe, N.W. Africa, W. and C. Asia

Length 16–18 in (41–45 cm)
Weight 10–25 oz (275–700 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Partial migrant
Status Least concern



The largest pigeon found in Europe, this species has prospered as a result of farming and has become an agricultural pest. It often feeds in flocks

on the ground, and is also an agile feeder in trees, clambering to branch tips to feast on fruit and seeds. Sexually active males perform a display flight, accompanied by wing claps, to attract a mate. The female usually produces only a single brood of one or 2 eggs per season. The young are cared for by both parents in the nest.



Nesoenus mayeri

Pink pigeon



Location Mauritius

Length 12–16¼ in (30–40 cm)
Weight 11–12 oz (300–325 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Endangered



One of the world’s rarest birds, the pink pigeon is one of many island species that have been harmed by introduced predators and habitat loss. The wild population had diminished to fewer than 20 birds in the 1980s; however, successful captive-breeding and release programs have led to an increase in its numbers. This large pigeon has a soft pink body, a white face and forehead, usually brown wings, and a moderately long, strong bill with a hooked tip.

Streptopelia decaocto

Eurasian collared-dove



Location Europe, Asia, N.E. Africa

Length 12–13½ in (31–34 cm)
Weight 5–7 oz (150–200 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Partial migrant
Status Least concern



This slim, pinkish buff dove, with its distinctive black collar, underwent a dramatic and still unexplained expansion during the 20th century, and has become a common sight through much of Europe. It feeds mainly on the seeds and fruit of grasses (including cereals) and herbs, and occasionally on invertebrates and the green parts of plants, typically pecking food from the ground. Highly vocal in the breeding season, its specific name “decaocto” indicates the rhythm of the male’s courtship call.



Zenaida macroura

Mourning dove



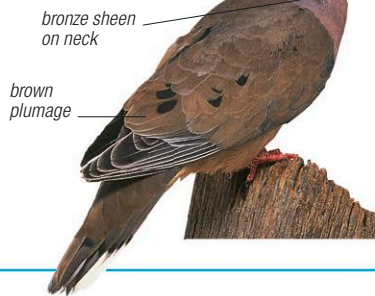
Location North and Central America, Caribbean

Length 9–13½ in (23–34 cm)
Weight 3½–6 oz (100–175 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Partial migrant
Status Least concern



The widespread North American dove gets its name from its mournful, 4-syllable call. Small and slender, it has long, narrow wings and a long, pointed

tail. The female is slightly paler than the male. The latter’s courtship display consists of gliding, spiraling, and flying above the female, with his wingtips held below the body. A very rapid breeder, this dove may even reproduce in the season of its birth.



Ptilinopus magnificus

Wompoo fruit dove



Location New Guinea, N.E. and E. Australia

Length 11½–22 in (29–55 cm)
Weight 9–18 oz (250–500 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Partial migrant
Status Least concern



Named the wompoo fruit dove after its “wompoo” call, this large, heavy, long-tailed fruit pigeon is threatened by loss of habitat. Despite its richly colored plumage—mostly yellow and green, with a deep purple breast and upper belly, and a gray or greenish gray head and neck—this bird is inconspicuous and surprisingly well camouflaged in the forest canopy in which it lives. It feeds on fruit (usually figs), taken from trees, and very rarely comes to the ground.

Hemiphaga novaeseelandiae

New Zealand pigeon



Location New Zealand

Length 18–20 in (46–50 cm)
Weight 21–29 oz (600–800 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Near threatened



The largest pigeon in New Zealand, this is the only species that is native to the islands, rather than introduced. It is dark, with iridescent, bronze and green highlights on the upperparts and breast, and a white belly and lower breast. This bird feeds on a wide range of plants and fruit, which it is able to eat whole because of its extendable gape. Several native New Zealand trees are almost totally dependent on this pigeon for their seed dispersal.



Goura scheepmakeri

Southern crowned-pigeon



Location S. New Guinea

Length 26–29 in (66–74 cm)
Weight 5½ lb (2.5 kg)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Vulnerable



One of the world’s largest pigeons, this species has a distinctive lacy, fan-shaped crest on top of its head.

Generally blue-gray, it has a purple-red breast and pale gray wing patches, edged with dark purple. It lives on the ground during the day, feeding on fallen fruit, and roosts in forest trees at night.

This species is now vulnerable as a result of loss of its forest habitat and humans hunting it for food and its beautiful plumes. Its rarity has also made it a target for collectors.

